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To cite this article: Amnon Cavari & Micah Ables (2019) Going Global: Assessing Presidential Foreign Travel, Congress & the Presidency, 46:2, 306-329, DOI: [10.1080/07343469.2018.1536173](https://doi.org/10.1080/07343469.2018.1536173)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/07343469.2018.1536173>



Published online: 04 Apr 2019.



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Going Global: Assessing Presidential Foreign Travel

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ABSTRACT

Since President Franklin Delano Roosevelt broke the “Ironclad Custom”—and especially following World War II—presidents have routinely traveled outside of the United States to visit other countries and meet foreign leaders and publics. Presidents are expected to engage in face-to-face diplomacy, but they must also be present and active in domestic politics. To balance these pressures, presidents need to be strategic and mindful of their limited political resources and the opportunities the political environment creates. How, then, do international and domestic political resources and opportunities affect the extent and frequency of foreign travel? To examine this question, we collected and analyzed a dataset of presidential foreign travel—number of trips, countries visited and days spent abroad—during the post-World War II period (1953–2016) and estimated the frequency of travel with a set of explanatory variables that capture U.S. foreign involvement as well as the domestic policy agenda and political incentives that affected presidents from Eisenhower to Obama. Our findings demonstrate that domestic policy and political incentives are strong determinants of presidential foreign travel.

On March 31, less than three months into his term, President Barack Obama made his first long trip abroad. His first stop was in London where he met with Queen Elizabeth II and Prime Minister Gordon Brown and attended the G-20 Economic Summit Meeting. From there he traveled to France and Germany for the NATO Summit Meeting and a working dinner with NATO leaders; to the Czech Republic to attend the U.S.-European Union Summit Meeting; to Turkey for a meeting with President Abdullah Gül and Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdoğan and to deliver an address to the Grand National Assembly in Ankara; and, finally, to Baghdad where he met with President Jalal Talabani and U.S. military personnel. Ten days later, President Obama traveled to Mexico where he met with President Felipe Calderón, and then continued to Trinidad and Tobago to attend the Summit of the Americas. In total, during his first 100 days in office, President Obama made 3 foreign trips (including an earlier short visit to

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Canada), visited 12 countries and spent 13 days abroad. By the end of his first year in office, President Obama had made 10 foreign trips, visited 21 countries, and spent 53 days abroad. The extent of President Obama's foreign travel in his first year in office is nearly double that of his predecessor (George W. Bush made 5 foreign trips to 11 countries and spent 26 days abroad) and successor (Donald Trump made 4 trips to 15 countries and spent 24 days abroad).¹ Together these three presidents demonstrate a strong contrast to a not-so-distant past when foreign presidential travel was traditionally forbidden by an idea known as the "Ironclad Custom." From President Truman to President Trump, presidents today routinely travel to foreign countries, but the scale, scope, and timing of presidential foreign travel varies between presidents and within their tenure in office.

Several studies examine the extent of presidential travel to foreign countries and the determinants of the timing and location of their trips (Brace and Hinckley 1993; Doherty 2009; Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Smith 1997). Most of these studies, however, rely on indirect measures of presidential travel (activities rather than actual trips) or lack sufficient theoretical development of the domestic factors that affect presidential foreign travel. In this article, we fill this void in the literature by offering and testing a theoretical model that focuses on domestic—policy and political—determinants of presidential foreign travel.

The article develops in five parts. First, we review the change in presidential foreign travel—from the Ironclad Custom to the current practice of foreign trips. Second, we review existing literature on this topic and on presidential public activities and propose a theoretical framework and an empirical model to examine presidential foreign travel. Third, we present our travel data—counts of presidential travel—and our explanatory variables. Fourth, we present our empirical analyses of the effect of international and domestic factors on the scale and scope of presidential foreign travel. Finally, we conclude with a discussion of the findings and limitations of our study.

Breaking the ironclad custom

For more than 100 years, presidential travel outside of the United States was prohibited by the Ironclad Custom. Presidents were constrained by norms and expectations that were rooted in the nation's understanding of its role in the world as a beacon of liberty that is above the fray of entangling alliances and power politics that characterized European monarchies. The republican government could remain small, decentralized, and unobtrusive only if it avoided taking part in the European power struggle. The president of the Republic was also expected to exhibit simplicity of

manners—distinguished and admired but a fellow citizen nonetheless. Hence, a president should avoid the dignitaries and ceremonies of monarchies around the world and should not be received by citizens of other countries as a monarch (Ellis 2008).

In addition to these norms and expectations, technology during the early years of the Republic limited such travel. When George Washington was president, passage across the Atlantic Ocean was dangerous and uncertain. Sailing ships could take anywhere from four to eight weeks to reach England. Hence, a trip to England would have kept the president away for several months; because there were no other forms of communication, the president would have been out of touch with the United States during his entire trip. This has gradually changed as innovations during the 19th century reduced the travel time to England to a week by steamship and the advent of the transatlantic telegraph cable which allowed presidents to stay informed about events back home.

President Theodore Roosevelt's visit to Panama is the first trip of a president to a foreign country. Understanding the strong taboo against foreign travel, the administration released an itinerary that included only locations within the American-controlled "Canal Zone." No mention was made of the president's visit to Panama City, especially his meetings with the Panamanian president and their exchange of public greetings and speeches (Ellis 2008, 170–172). That trip and the trip of his successor, William Howard Taft, to Juarez, Mexico, were indeed firsts, but they were regarded as only minor departures from the custom.

In his attempts to create the League of Nations, President Woodrow Wilson is the first president to have made an official trip to a foreign country (France). However, following this visit—regarded at the time as a political mistake (Ellis 2008, 177–93)—his successors refrained from such trips and limited themselves to traveling close to the borders and only visiting Canada (Warren G. Harding) and Cuba (Calvin Coolidge).

The proscription against foreign travel completely crumbled during Franklin Roosevelt's presidency. In his first term, the change was small—traveling to Canada, Haiti, Colombia, and Panama. However, following his reelection in 1936 and especially after the outbreak of World War II, President Roosevelt traveled across the globe showing no sign that such travels are, or should be, limited.

During the post-World Wars era, the the importance of foreign policy and of interacting with the rest of the world has dramatically increased for American presidents. To maintain U.S. national security and the health of the economy in a global environment, presidents today find it necessary to cooperate, with bargain, and influence other executives around the world (Rose 1993; Smith 1997). As commander-in-chief leading an army that is

permanently stationed around the world and managing a global foreign policy, the president is required to be visible, defend America's foreign interests, and marshal and direct hard power resources to advance his foreign policy agenda. The increased involvement of the United States in the global community requires presidents to conduct face-to-face diplomacy to ensure the cooperation of allies and to promote the president's economic and foreign policy agendas (Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Marra, Ostrom, and Simon 1990; Rose 1988).

To accomplish these goals, presidents are expected to “go international,” travel to foreign countries to represent the United States on the global stage, where they meet, collaborate, and negotiate with other world leaders to promote exports, initiate bilateral projects, and sign treaties and contracts (Cohen 2016; Nitsch 2007; Rose 1993; Smith 1997). This expectation has been amplified by advances in technology such as Air Force One, the advent of in-air refueling, and the development of sophisticated and secured communication technologies, all of which afford presidents more opportunities to travel abroad while maintaining their involvement in domestic politics (Ellis 2008).

Following Franklin Roosevelt's lead, presidents from Truman to Obama have taken nearly 300 trips abroad, visited more than 100 foreign countries, and spent more than 1,500 days outside of the United States. However, as the aforementioned comparison of the three most recent presidents illustrates, presidents vary in the extent of foreign travel and the timing of their travel throughout their tenure in office. Therefore, our interest is to explain the variation in presidential travel across presidents and for each president. Recent work has examined the effect of international and foreign policy factors on presidential foreign travel, but how do domestic policy and politics explain the variation in presidential foreign travel? We address this question empirically using data on presidential travel and additional explanatory factors from Eisenhower to Obama (1953–2016).

Theoretical framework

Presidents are strategic actors who carefully allocate their scarce resources. They need to travel abroad to engage in face-to-face diplomacy, but they must also be present and active in national politics. Some trips, such as to summits of world leaders, are perceived as all but mandatory for presidents (though presidents skip them when necessary), whereas other trips, such as President Obama's trip to the Middle East and his public speech in Cairo on June 4, 2009, are at the discretion of the president. Some trips and visits to countries are added to an already planned trip—such as President Obama's visit to London before attending the NATO meeting in April

2009—whereas others are independently scheduled, such as President Obama's trips to Riyadh and Cairo in June 2009. What, then, explains presidents' decisions to travel and the timing of their travel?²

In what is perhaps the most extensive study of the topic to date, Lebovic and Saunders (2016) examine the determinants of high-level U.S. diplomatic visits from Truman to Obama. Their focus is on bilateral visits—whether a visit occurred to a specific country within a year. Therefore, most of their interest is in the bilateral determinants of a visit: military spending, military aid, treaties, alliances, trade, and more. They acknowledge, though, that these visits are also conditioned on domestic opportunities and constraints that affect *how much* presidents engage in personal diplomacy.

To account for these domestic influences, Lebovic and Saunders (2016) include binary indicators for each president: party affiliation of the president, party control of Congress (divided government and political balance in Congress), and term in office. They find little evidence of domestic influence—weak variance among administrations and no effect of party affiliation or political balance with Congress—but find that political time matters. Presidents engage in more personal diplomacy during their second term in office.

Their estimation strategy and their selection of variables offer excellent leverage to assess the effect of strategic factors and international practice in bilateral visits, but they do not fully assess how domestic factors affect presidential travel. First, their unit of observation is year-country visit (coded 1 for a year with a country-visit and 0 otherwise) and therefore is appropriate for estimating the likelihood that a visit to a specific country in a specific year would take place. Accordingly, all variables they use to assess strategic factors and international practice vary by year and location. The domestic factors offer the least variation—aggregated to presidential or congressional terms. These domestic factors offer little leverage to assess why, for example, President Obama would travel to Egypt in 2009 but travel to Brazil in 2011. It is, therefore, not surprising that these domestic factors are not statistically significant.

Furthermore, a focus on domestic influences on presidential actions should not be limited to president-centered factors. The rich body of work on presidential actions has established that presidents are attentive to the policy environment and to political considerations such as the policy agenda, public interest, and levels of approval (see, for example, Cavari 2017; Cohen 2008, 2010; Heith 2013). A study of presidential action should account for these factors.

Building on the work of Lebovic and Saunders (2016) and the work of others that examine other features of presidential action, we outline three

primary domains of influence that create the opportunities for and constraints on presidential travel: international involvement, policy agenda, and political considerations. We explain each domain separately.

International involvement

The foreign policy agenda of a president is affected by world affairs and the level of U.S. involvement in them (Martin 2005; Walt 2005). A dominant factor affecting the United States' involvement and role in the world is the end of the Cold War, which altered military and economic barriers that existed during the Cold War and changed the role of the United States on the global stage. Any estimation of the determinants of travel should therefore account for this change in behavior.

Beyond this dramatic shift, presidents represent the United States on the global stage and, therefore, we expect presidents' travel schedules to change as American military and economic involvement in the world waxes and wanes. For example, President George W. Bush visited Baghdad, Iraq, in 2006 to discuss security and economic strategies with Prime Minister Nouri al-Maliki, and President Obama traveled to Brazil, Chile, and El Salvador in 2011 to improve economic relations with the region.

We, therefore, expect that when the United States is called for or engaged in more military operations abroad, presidents would emphasize their role as commander-in-chief by traveling around the world more often to build, strengthen, and reaffirm alliances. Similarly, when trade balance declines—the United States exports less than it imports—presidents would travel as a negotiator-in-chief to open new markets and improve existing ones (Nitsch 2007).

H1. Presidents travel more when the level of military engagement increases.

H2. Presidents travel more when the balance between exports and imports drops (less exports relative to imports).

Policy agenda

It is reasonable to expect that a president would “give primacy to his domestic calculus” when formulating a foreign policy (Putnam 1988, 457). Thus, we expect that active participation in the international sphere is greatly affected by the tools and strategies that are granted or constrained by the domestic policy agenda (Kriner 2009).

Presidents act based on the pressures of the policy agenda that they face. To create a foreign policy and overall “national interest” amid the various competing priorities, presidents must contend with the legislature,

governmental institutions, interest groups, and public attention (Milner 1992). To understand the impact of “the black box of domestic politics” (Bueno de Mesquita and Lalman 1992) on presidents’ actions, we examine the effect of the policy environment, public agenda, and congressional agenda. Each of these factors possesses the powerful ability to raise awareness about various issues, thus steering the policy-making process and affecting the president’s focus (Baumgartner and Jones 2015; Cobb and Elder 1972; Edwards and Wood 1999; Light 1991; Wood and Peake 1998).

First, we expect that the policy agenda would affect the extent to which the political system is focused and can focus on foreign events. A key factor in this focus is the state of the economy, which consumes much of the public’s attention. When the economy is in decline, the entire political system is focused on it. During this time, the president is expected to focus on the economy and avoid foreign endeavors.

H3. Presidents travel less when the economy is weak.

Beyond the strong effect of the objective condition of the economy, presidents can use foreign travel to divert attention from domestic issues. According to the now-rich work on diversionary theory, presidents can divert public and elite attention from domestic issues to foreign policy by deploying troops to improve their public standing and electoral fortunes (Brace and Hinckley 1993; DeRouen 1995, 2000; Hess and Orphanides 1995; James and Rioux 1998; Mintz 2004).³ However, presidents are mindful of the cost of using force and the temporal gain it may generate and are therefore careful in using force to divert attention. Presidents prefer to have high levels of support and strong electoral margins before engaging in extensive foreign policy activity (Ostrom and Job 1986; Potter 2013). They may, therefore, opt for more peaceful means of diverting attention. Andrade (1996) and Andrade and Young (2003) demonstrate that presidents can divert attention from domestic issues and focus the public agenda on foreign policy by “going public” on foreign affairs. Similarly, Wood (2012) finds that presidents often threaten or engage in rhetorical war with other countries—“saber rattling”—as a way to focus attention on foreign affairs, affect electoral outcomes, and bolster domestic support.

Following the same reasoning, presidents can divert attention by traveling abroad, meeting with world leaders, and delivering speeches to foreign audiences. We therefore expect that presidents will respond to public concern about domestic issues—most significantly, the economy—by focusing on foreign issues and traveling abroad. This effect is expected to be marginal compared to instances of a weakening economy as predicted in H3. When the economy is in a dramatic decline, presidents would find it difficult to divert attention; however, when economic indicators are more

stable, presidents may yet be able to divert lingering public attention away from existing concerns about the economy.

H4. Presidents travel more when public concern about the economy increases.

Finally, although the president has broad powers to conduct foreign policy, Congress has the tools to affect foreign policy and to influence the president's agenda. Members of Congress tend to avoid foreign affairs, but when they decide to muddy their hands with this issue they limit the power of the president and affect his actions (Howell and Pevehouse 2007; Kriner 2010). Presidents avoid a direct confrontation with Congress and prefer to sidestep an issue Congress is strongly involved in (Cohen 2012). Therefore, when Congress is active in foreign affairs, we expect presidents to lower their profile and avoid travel.

H5. Presidents travel less when members of Congress are actively engaged in foreign affairs.

Political considerations

Last, one cannot assess presidential actions without also considering the political environment in which the president operates. Presidents are political actors who are attuned to their political standing—their level of public approval, their power balance with Congress, and the political calendar.

Public opinion toward the president can often motivate the president to focus on foreign affairs. Beginning with Mueller's (1970) assertion of a "rally-round-the-flag" effect, conventional wisdom has coalesced around the idea that "presidential actions in the foreign arena enhance the public standing of the president" (Marra, Ostrom, and Simon 1990, 592). Whereas the immediate response in approval is "transitory"—often as short as 30 days (Marra, Ostrom, and Simon 1990)—traveling abroad offers the president a chance to improve his political currency in the form of public opinion polls (Mackuen 1983). Thus, for a narrowly elected president or one that teeters on razor-thin approval margins, international diplomacy is an opportunity to climb in the polls, no matter how small the gain may be (Potter 2013).

One example of this is President Bill Clinton's travels in the summer of 1994. Following the January 1994 disclosure of the Paula Jones incident in the *American Spectator* and Jones' subsequent sexual harassment suit filed against President Clinton in May of that year, Clinton, facing his lowest approval ratings in more than nine months, began a six-day, five-country tour of Europe. As his approval ratings continued to drop to the lowest levels in a year, he embarked on another whirlwind six-day, four-country journey the following month.

The president's ability to manipulate or manage public support through foreign policy focus should logically lead to an increase in presidential actions abroad (Canes-Wrone 2009; Geer 1996; Marra, Ostrom, and Simon 1990). Indeed, early work has shown that presidential foreign travel is inversely related to approval (Brace and Hinckley 1993), reflecting the president's belief that emphasizing certain issues and being seen as a national leader on the international stage can positively influence public perceptions (Druckman and Jacobs 2009).

H6. Presidents travel more when their approval ratings are low.

Another dominant impact on presidential activities is the political environment in Washington. Presidents respond to the political environment by searching opportunities to lead and promote policy. Viewing presidential travel through the lens of game theory, the president, as a rational actor, may respond to the political environment and conduct a cost-benefit analysis to maximize his expected utility by engaging in foreign affairs (Kriner 2009; Lebovic and Saunders 2016). This may be strongly affected by the strength of the political divide—mainly, party control and party polarization in Congress. First, when presidents are facing a divided government, they find it more difficult to push their domestic agenda (Cohen 2012; Coleman 1999; Fleisher, Bond, and Wood 2008; Ragsdale 2009) and therefore may revert to foreign policy where they are less constrained by Congress. Second, when the parties are polarized on policy, the president may look for an opportunity to create consensus, build unity, and call for “politics to stop at the water's edge” by personally engaging in diplomacy abroad (Smith 1997, 222). This theoretical expectation can be illustrated in President George H.W. Bush's 1991 attempt to revive Israeli-Palestinian dialogue during the Madrid Conference. Facing Democratic majorities in both houses of Congress and after breaking his “no new taxes” campaign promise, Bush may have sought to take advantage of his foreign policy edge by personally applying the Gulf War momentum and political capital to the stalled Arab-Israeli peace process. Although these types of diplomatic missions are announced in the context of foreign policy objectives, they are closely related to support for the president's agenda at home (Brace and Hinckley 1993).

The interaction between the two, however, creates a different political environment (Cohen 2012). Divided governments and high party polarization introduce excessive burdens on government function (Binder 2004). Therefore, the extent of presidential travel—as all other presidential activities—may be muted when the president is facing a divided government and Congress is strongly divided with a vocal majority against the president and his agenda.

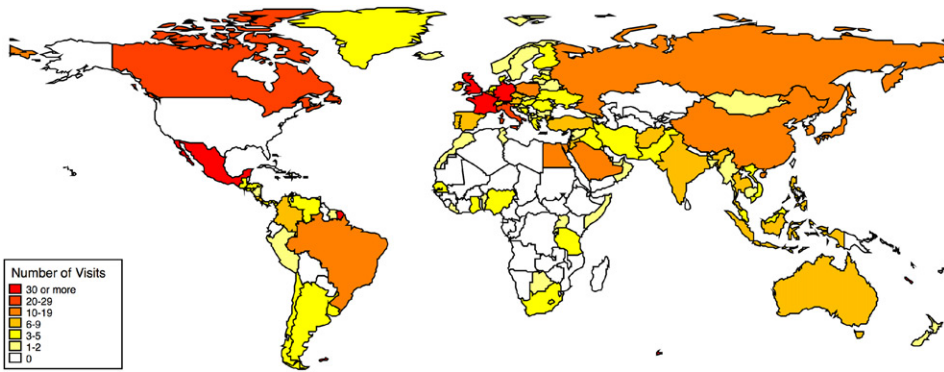


Figure 1. Scale and scope of presidential trips abroad, Truman to Obama, 1945–2016.

Note: Data are from the U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Public Affairs, Office of the Historian.

H7. Presidents travel more when they face a divided government *or* when Congress is polarized, but they travel less when government is divided *and* Congress is polarized.

Finally, an extant body of literature has established that the political calendar affects presidential activities (Brace and Hinckley 1993). We expect it to be the same for presidential foreign travel—mainly in election years and in the final lame duck years of their presidency. During an election year, incumbent presidents focus on their reelection bids by traveling across the country, holding campaign events, and issuing frequent responses to the rhetoric and actions of their challengers (Doherty 2009). Foreign travel would take them away from their constituents and limit their ability to respond to the demands of their campaign. Thus, we expect that presidents avoid foreign travel during their election bids.

In turn, during their final years in office, presidents may attempt to divert attention from “lame duck” struggles and their loss of political capital (Barrett and Eshbaugh-Soha 2007). The relative autonomy that presidents have in foreign policy offers lame duck presidents an opportunity to avoid this loss of power, fulfill an ambitious agenda, and cement an historical legacy that is not constrained by domestic politics. Potter (2016) demonstrates that as their political capital decreases, lame duck presidents also increase public diplomacy and the use of force.

This effect can be seen in numerous presidencies, particularly that of President George W. Bush. He started his final year in office with a farewell visit to Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Olmert, Israeli President Shimon Peres, and Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas as well as visits to U.S. troops in the Persian Gulf; he continued with a tour of Africa to cement his legacy of generous support for the continent; and he spent his last foreign presidential visit with American troops in Afghanistan and Iraq, the sites of his most enduring and visible foreign policy legacy. We therefore expect presidents to

revamp their foreign travel schedule during their final years in office to travel more frequently, to more countries, and to spend more time abroad.

H8. Presidents travel less during their reelection bid, but travel more during their final—lame duck—years of their presidency.

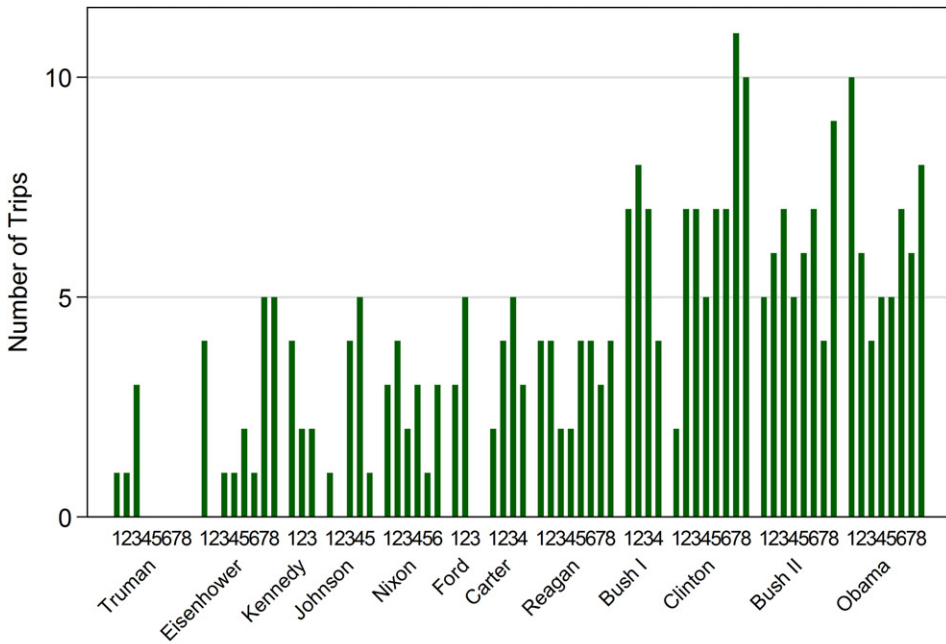
Data and method

To measure presidential travel, we rely on data from the U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Public Affairs, Office of the Historian.⁴ The Office of the Historian lists every foreign trip of presidents and secretaries of state including the location, duration, and major action of each foreign trip.

To first illustrate the extent of presidential foreign travel, we plot the reach of presidential visits and the volume of travel over time. [Figure 1](#) illustrates the scope of presidential travel from Truman to Obama (1945–2016) by plotting the destinations of presidential travel. Each country a president has visited is colored.⁵ The yellow (light) to red (dark) color scale reflects the number of presidential visits in a country over the entire period—a lighter (yellow) color stands for few visits (one or two) and a stronger (red) color stands for numerous visits (30 or more). Except for many African countries, presidents have visited most countries in the world, returning to several countries numerous times—especially neighboring countries (Canada and Mexico), European allies (United Kingdom, France, Germany, and Italy), and major world and regional powers or allies (Brazil, China, Egypt, Israel, Japan, and Russia).

Not all presidents traveled at the same rate and each president shows significant variation in his travel schedule throughout his tenure. [Figure 2](#) plots the number of trips of each president from Truman to Obama in each year in office (1945–2016). Except for Truman, every president traveled nearly every year in office. The number of trips was relatively modest from Truman to Reagan, averaging fewer than three trips each year. This changed dramatically following the end of the Cold War and the rapid increase of globalization (Smith 1997). From President George H.W. Bush forward, presidents made on average more than six trips each year.

To further illustrate the change in presidential travel, we examine three related series. The first series—the one discussed previously—is the number of trips presidents take. A trip is defined as an event in which the president leaves the United States. The two additional measures of presidential travel are of the extent of travel—how many countries presidents visit and how many days they spend abroad. Adding to the value of measuring the scale of presidential foreign travel, the two series also allow us to check on the possibility that our results are driven by a change in the number of trips presidents may feel obligated to make due to the rise of multinational summits.



* Number of trips per president in each year in office.

Figure 2. Number of trips abroad: Truman to Obama, 1945–2016.

Note: Data are from the U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Public Affairs, Office of the Historian.

As is illustrated in the first three foreign trips of President Obama, when presidents travel to what we—and they—may view as near-mandatory trips, such as to NATO summits or Summits of the Americas, they often extend their trip to visit other countries and spend more time abroad. These are beyond the so-called mandatory trips and therefore may further reveal the effect of domestic policy and politics on presidential foreign travel.

The three series—aggregated to annual means—are plotted in [Figure 3](#). Although considerable variation occurs between years, the general trend is similar to what we observed when looking only at the number of trips. During the post-World Wars period, presidents routinely travel to foreign countries. Since the end of the Cold War, presidents take more trips, visit more countries, and spend more time outside of the United States.

To empirically examine the hypothesized determinants of travel, we focus on presidents from Eisenhower forward, all of which traveled routinely. We use the following explanatory variables in our models:

U.S. international involvement. We control for changes in the international environment following the end of the Cold War (defined as the fall of the Berlin Wall) by including an indicator for post-Cold War era (1 if after November 1989, 0 otherwise). Adding to that, we include a covariate for

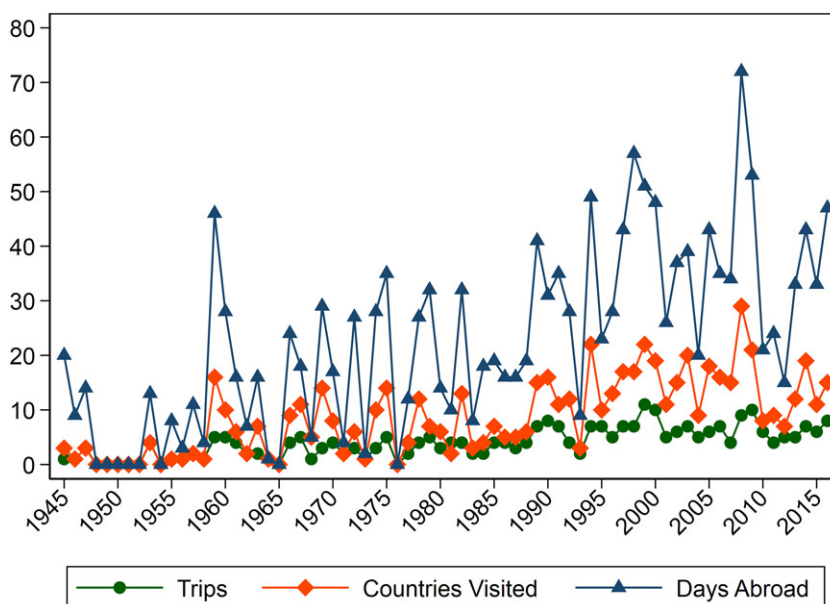


Figure 3. Trends in presidential travel, 1945–2016.

Note: Data are from the U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Public Affairs, Office of the Historian. All series are aggregated to annual sums.

U.S. opportunities to use force. Our measure is based on the Militarized Interstate Dispute (MID) data compiled by the Correlates of War (COW) Project. The project codes for the level of hostility of the particular dispute—ranging from no militarized action (1) to war (5). Because the level of hostility may affect the level of involvement of the United States, we applied the hostility weights to the number of disputes which the United States is a party to (*U.S. Disputes*). The MID data offer exact start and end dates. Based on these dates, we can generate a list of events occurring—starting or ongoing—in every given period. For example, in 1995, there was one new dispute that the United States was a party to, but three additional lingering disputes. These four events vary in their hostility weights—summing up to 13.⁶

To measure the use, commitment, and visibility of American hard power in the world, we use the number of U.S. troops deployed or stationed abroad per year (*Troops*, measured in units of 100,000). Data on troop deployment are from various Pentagon records as integrated by Tim Kane to annual sums of troops deployed by country and region (Kane 2016).⁷

To measure the change in the balance of economic relations, we use the balance of trade accounts (*Trade Balance*)—that is, the difference between import and export markets as a percentage of the current GDP divided by the contemporary GDP to ensure we are comparing real-time effects on the economy. Data are from the Federal Reserve.

To allow for causal testing, we use the lagged terms (1 lag) for U.S. disputes and troop deployment. Given the dramatic shift in the balance between exports and imports in the period examined—dropping rapidly from relative balance until the late 1970s—to a consistent and growing deficit—we use change in trade balance from $t - 1$ to t .

Policy agenda. To gauge the salience of foreign affairs on the political agenda, we include measures of the public, congressional, and policy agendas. First, as a strong measure of policy focus, we include the seasonally adjusted aggregated unemployment rates from the Federal Reserve Economic Data (*Unemployment*). The seasonally adjusted series is best for accounting for the underlying trends in unemployment rates, which is more appropriate for assessing general trends of elite actions.

Second, for public perspectives on the importance of domestic affairs, we use the Gallup's Most Important Problem survey series, which asks individuals to choose what they feel is the most important problem facing the nation. Relying on coding by the Policy Agendas Project, we aggregate all economy-related responses to generate a measure of economic interest (*MIP Economy*).

Finally, we include a covariate of congressional attention to foreign policy, using the sum of congressional hearings that focus on foreign affairs. These data are available from the Policy Agendas Project (*Hearings Foreign*).

Unemployment, Hearings, and MIP are lagged (1 lag) to allow for causal testing.

Political environment. We include a number of variables to describe the domestic political environment. First, we account for presidential approval using Gallup's presidential approval ratings (*Approval*). For relationship with Congress we use an indicator for divided government (one or both chambers not controlled by the party of the president). Level of party polarization (in the Senate) is measured using DW-Nominate's scores for difference in party means in the Senate (*Polarization Senate*). We also include an interaction between the two (*Divided X Polarization*)—accounting for situations of divided government with the president facing a combative Congress. Although divided government and polarization represent a current state of the political system, approval is lagged (1 lag) to allow for causal testing (with the exception of administration change where we use the current ratings).

Political calendar. We use a dummy variable to indicate whether a year is an election year (*Election*). We use an ordinal variable to indicate whether it is the seventh or eighth year of a presidency (*Lame*): coding 1 the first

year after the final midterm election and 2 for the president's final year in office.⁸

Because our interest is in the extent of travel rather than individual visits, we need to aggregate the data to meaningful units of observation. In deciding the level of aggregation—months, quarters, half-years, or years—we consider theoretical justifications, an interest in causal testing, and the need to minimize missing data or repeated observations.

Theoretically, we argue that detailed series, such as months or quarters, are not justified because of the relatively fixed schedule of the president, especially for foreign travel. Some presidential travel is short notice and reactive to current events—for example, President Lyndon B. Johnson's West Germany trip for Chancellor Konrad Adenauer's funeral, or President George H.W. Bush's attendance at the funeral for Japan's Emperor Hirohito. However, most presidential activities require advance planning because of the extensive coordination involved in these visits.

Between annual and semiannual aggregation, we prefer semiannual because it offers better causal testing and our data allow that. Most of the variables—U.S. disputes, trade balance, unemployment, MIP, congressional hearings, and presidential approval—provide semiannual variation. Level of troops and measures of the political calendar (election and lame years) provide annual variation. In addition, the two variables that account for the political environment—divided government and polarization in the Senate—offer bi-annual variation.

Given that the time-series data generated by time aggregation, we first test whether the three travel series follow an identifiable generating process. Because of the count dependent variables, we examine the autocorrelation and partial autocorrelation trends on the standardized values (Cameron and Trivedi 1998). None suggest an autoregressive or moving average process. As an additional check, we tested our full models using appropriate count time series estimators including a first lag autoregressive component. We include these models in the appendix. These models confirm our diagnostics tests: The autoregressive coefficient is not significant in any of the models. This is an important finding which strengthens our following analysis. Presidential foreign travel is explained by domestic and foreign events, rather than being representative of an identifiable growing trend of presidential activities. It also supports our interest in modeling all modern presidents together.

Finally, to account for the differences between presidents and the effect of time on the challenges and opportunities each president faces, we cluster the standard errors by president. Because our dependent variable in all models is a count, we use Poisson estimators. Tests for overdispersion do

not support using negative binomial regression models. Because of the relative consistency of travel, zeros are not inflated and therefore we find no theoretical or empirical support for zero inflated models. Because of incomplete series, especially the U.S. Disputes series, all models are estimated on data from 1953 to 2011. Dropping the U.S. Disputes series extends the data to 2015, resulting in no change to the overall findings.

Results

The standardized coefficients of the three travel models are summarized in Table 1. Column 1 summarizes the trips model—how many times a president travels to foreign countries in a half-year period. Column 2 summarizes the countries model—to how many countries a president travels in a half-year period. Column 3 summarizes the days model—how many days a president travels abroad in a half-year period.

The results support several of our expectations. As Figures 2 and 3 suggest, presidents have traveled more following the collapse of the Soviet Union and the end of the Cold War. In terms of incident rate ratios, the effect is substantive. The percentage change in the expected count of trips

Table 1. Assessing determinants of presidential foreign travel.

	(1) Trips	(2) Countries	(3) Days
Post-Cold War	0.48*** (0.13)	0.64** (0.20)	0.38* (0.18)
US Disputes (t – 1)	0.00 (0.02)	–0.02 (0.03)	–0.03 (0.03)
Troops (t – 1)	–0.02 (0.02)	0.04 (0.04)	–0.00 (0.03)
Trade Balance (change, t, t – 1)	–0.48** (0.15)	–0.59 (0.40)	–0.56 (0.45)
Unemployment (t – 1)	–0.14** (0.05)	–0.21** (0.07)	–0.24*** (0.06)
Public Agenda (MIP Economy, t – 1)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02* (0.01)	0.02** (0.01)
Congressional Agenda (Hearings, Foreign, t – 1)	–0.04** (0.01)	–0.06*** (0.02)	–0.05*** (0.01)
Presidential Approval (t – 1)	0.01 (0.00)	–0.00 (0.00)	–0.00 (0.00)
Divided Government (t)	0.81* (0.32)	0.89** (0.33)	1.17* (0.47)
Polarization (Senate) (t)	2.26*** (0.47)	3.23*** (0.61)	3.34*** (0.49)
Divided X Polarization	–1.30** (0.47)	–1.38* (0.55)	–1.68* (0.73)
Election Year (t)	–0.43** (0.15)	–0.48* (0.19)	–0.42 (0.23)
Lame Duck (t, ordinal, final 2 years)	0.41*** (0.11)	0.43* (0.18)	0.40* (0.20)
Constant	0.08 (0.46)	0.95 (0.50)	2.03*** (0.59)
N	117	117	117

Poisson Count models.

Standardized beta coefficients; Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

during the post-Cold War period is 62. The expected change is larger for the count of countries (89%) and is somewhat smaller (46%) for the count of days abroad. This effect should not be attributed only to the international environment that is altered by the end of the Cold War. The end of the Cold War has been affected by, aligned with, and has affected massive global, technological, and domestic transformations, all of which are associated with the need, the opportunity, and the ease of travel.

We find no significant effect of the weighted count of U.S. disputes nor for troop deployment. Presidents do not travel more (or less) when the U.S. is involved in or has the opportunity to engage in military actions around the world (no support for H1). Replacing troop deployment with a measure of overall military engagement which accounts for the number of countries in which troops are deployed and the level of troops in each of them offers no additional leverage.⁹

In contrast to the military engagement covariates, we find a negative association between change in trade balance and presidential travel. Presidents travel more frequently when there is a decrease in exports versus imports (support for H2). This suggests that presidents understand their role in international coordination for boosting exports. The effect is not very large (expected change of 6% for one standard deviation change in trade balance). However, the variable is already a measure of change ($t-1$, t) and therefore we find this to be an important indication of presidential calculations for travel.

The political agenda offers more predictive power on the extent of presidential travel. Unemployment is negatively associated with the count of trips, countries, and days abroad (support for H3). For a change of one standard deviation in unemployment rate, the expected number of trips, countries, and days abroad decreases by 20%, 29%, and 32% respectively. Public concern about the economy is positively associated with presidential travel (weak support for H4). When the public is concerned about the economy, presidents travel more, thus offering some support to a softer version of the diversionary theory. The effect however, is extremely small—at about 2% expected change in all models (the variable in the count of trips model is smaller and is significant only at the 90% level). Moreover, as expected, when we include an interaction between unemployment and public concern (not included in the models presented here), the interaction term is significant and negative (the same sign as unemployment) indicating that economic conditions trump public sentiments. Therefore, though the direction of the effect of public concern with the economy is indicative of our expected association, it is difficult to draw any meaningful conclusions from such a small effect.

Finally, congressional attention to foreign policy is negatively associated with presidential travel (support for H5). The standardized effects are about

15% change (decrease) in expected count in each model. Indeed, as expected, presidents travel less when Congress is actively engaged in foreign affairs.

The political environment has a strong effect on the presidential travel schedule. Presidential approval has no effect on travel (no support for H6)—presidents neither increase nor decrease their foreign travel when they have weak public approval. But, we find strong support for our other expectations. Presidents travel more when they are facing a divided government and when the partisan debate in Congress is polarized, yet, when they face an oppositional and polarized Congress (interaction term), they tend to decrease their travel (support for H7). During more stable political periods of unified government and weak polarization (reference category), presidents travel less—though more than the heated environment of divided and polarized. All these effects are substantially large, demonstrating the importance of the political environment on presidential actions. In addition, as expected in our final hypothesis (H8), presidents travel less frequently (35%) and to fewer countries (38%) during election years but take more trips (50%) to more countries (54%) and spend more time (50%) traveling in the final, lame-duck years of their presidency.

Discussion

In modern times, presidents are expected to travel abroad to engage in face-to-face diplomacy, but they must also be present and active in national politics. To balance these competing pressures and others, presidents strategically and carefully use their limited resources. Adding to the recent work on the international factors that affect presidential travel, our empirical evidence aims to test how presidents weigh these domestic pressures. The results suggest that in their foreign travel plans and schedule, presidents consider the domestic policy pressures and the political environment in which they operate.

The policy agenda has a strong effect on presidential foreign travel. Presidents understand that domestic problems come first—if the economy is in shambles, they cannot travel around the globe and speak to foreign audiences. Presidents need to handle this issue. However, controlling for the dominant impact of the economy, when presidents identify a strong public concern with the economy they may try to divert attention by initiating interest in foreign affairs. This effect, however, is marginal compared to the strong effect of the state of the economy.

Beyond the policy agenda, presidents appear to be mindful of the opportunities and limitations of the political environment and utilize them when deciding whether to travel. Although their travel plans do not seem to be affected by their approval ratings, presidents respond to the balance of

power with Congress. Presidents travel more when they are facing a divided government and when the political environment is polarized, but they travel less when they face a strong opposition that hampers the ability of the president to manage his agenda (Cohen 2012). This adds to the effect of congressional hearings; when Congress takes an active role in foreign policy, presidents avoid the highly publicized events of foreign travel.

Finally, presidents are mindful of the political calendar. They avoid foreign trips during their reelection bids so they can actively campaign and quickly respond to political events. In contrast, in their final years in office, presidents pivot away from their loss of political power in Washington and turn more to foreign travel which they can use to take a victory lap and attempt to cement their foreign policy legacy.

Our limited findings regarding the international environment—troop deployment and U.S. disputes—suggest that presidents do not travel in the capacity of commander-in-chief. These factors may not affect the travel plans of the president, but the null effects may also be due to the limitations of our international indicators. Both covariates do not represent adequately the extent of U.S. engagement in world affairs and lack the nuance that characterizes the current global environment—the types of conflicts and the varied ways that the United States can respond to or affect them. In addition, perhaps during military engagements presidents increase their foreign outreach using other means such as telephone conversations or hosting foreign leaders in the United States. Our data, however, do not allow us to examine these possibilities, and assessing meetings with foreign leaders in Washington or phone conversations is beyond the scope of this study.

Adding to that, we find several important limitations in this study. First, the dearth of data may limit the understanding of causality and the broad applicability of our study. Although our independent variable datasets are rich, we were simply constrained by the limited variation in our dependent variable. This is partly due to the low number of trips presidents take as well as the relative novelty of international presidential activities. This lack of data points has also impacted the existing body of research. With minimal empirical analyses available and theories based primarily on case studies of one or two presidents, there is very little consensus in the literature on how or when presidential travel may occur.

Another limitation that frustrated our study is the lack of some sort of “chaos index,” or a metric that can indicate whether the international arena was calm or frenzied, whether due to a stock market meltdown, tsunami, or a wave of popular revolutions. Creating such an index is outside the scope of this project, but such a variable could go a long way to clarifying the relationship between the president’s international travels and the global

environment. As more data become available, other trends and relationships may become more obvious that could provide more fertile ground for further research.

Finally, the focus of this article is to determine what factors might propel a president to leave the country; as such, our models seek to identify those factors. There is more to understand regarding foreign travel and foreign activity more broadly. Further research should be conducted to find out *why* certain factors have specific impacts. For instance, why do international conflicts and public opinion affect the president's policy focus but not his travel schedule? Why wouldn't the president's international activities be matched with his policy goals? We hope that our work initiates research on this important activity of presidents that has, until recently, defied empirical analysis.

Notes

1. Data on presidential foreign travel obtained from the U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Public Affairs, Office of the Historian.
2. In this study, we do not examine the effects of presidential foreign travel. See, for example, Brace and Hinckley (1993) and Cohen (2016).
3. The connection between domestic problems and foreign actions also affects other countries. Fordham (2005) demonstrates that countries which are likely targets of diversionary use of force by the United States behave more cooperatively when the American economy is performing poorly.
4. Available online at <https://history.state.gov/>
5. Visits to the Soviet Union are attributed to Russia even if the president visited a territory that later became part of an independent former Soviet Union country.
6. The new dispute (number 4064 in the COW data) consists of a series of incidents in which China sought to intimidate Taiwan away from moves toward independence and Taiwanese and American responses to these Chinese actions. Hostility level =3. The three lingering disputes are from 1992 and 1994. The first, starting in 1992 (COW number, 3551), refers to the response of Western countries—United States included—to the involvement of Yugoslavia in the Bosnian civil war. Hostility level =4. The second, from 1994 (COW number 4087), refers to a series of disputes between North Korea and South Korea over territorial boundaries along the Korean Demilitarized Zone (DMZ) and in the waters along the Northern Limit Line. During the dispute, North Korean forces shot down an American helicopter that had strayed across the DMZ (December 1994). Hostility level =3. The third, also starting in 1994 (COW number 4269), refers to several occasions after the end of the Gulf War in which Iraq sent troops and took other hostile actions directed at Kuwait. Iraqi actions provoked responses from members of the Gulf War coalition both to reinforce the border and to signal to Iraq that its action would not be tolerated. Hostility level =3. For more information about the disputes, see the Correlates of War Project at <http://cow.dss.ucdavis.edu/data-sets/MIDs> (last visited, August 12, 2018).
7. We thank Tim Kane for sharing the data with us.

8. We code only the second half of 1968 as lame duck. President Johnson announced that he would not run for reelection only in March 1968. Until then he was an incumbent running for reelection and was viewed and acted as such.
9. This alternative measure is based on Tim Kane's measure of engagement and is the annual sum of the logs of troops deployed in each country. This measure reflects the overall number of troops and the number of countries the United States is involved in militarily. Similar to our troops' covariate, we applied a lagged (1 lag) measure of engagement.

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Appendix

Robustness Check, Model with Autocorrelation (1 lag)

	(1) Trips	(2) Countries	(3) Days
AR1	–0.19 (0.10)	–0.16 (0.10)	–0.16 (0.10)
Post-Cold War	0.52 (0.27)	0.69* (0.33)	0.42 (0.35)
U.S. Disputes (t – 1)	–0.00 (0.04)	–0.02 (0.04)	–0.03 (0.05)
Troops (t – 1)	–0.02 (0.05)	0.05 (0.05)	–0.00 (0.06)
Trade Balance (change, t, t – 1)	–0.41 (0.42)	–0.57 (0.48)	–0.52 (0.53)
Unemployment (t – 1)	–0.13 (0.07)	–0.20* (0.09)	–0.23* (0.09)
Public Agenda (MIP Economy, t – 1)	0.01 (0.01)	0.02* (0.01)	0.02* (0.01)
Congressional Agenda (Hearings, Foreign, t – 1)	–0.04 (0.02)	–0.06* (0.03)	–0.05 (0.03)
Presidential Approval (t – 1)	0.01 (0.01)	–0.00 (0.01)	–0.00 (0.01)
Divided Government (t)	0.82 (0.67)	0.91 (0.81)	1.16 (0.87)
Polarization (Senate) (t)	2.21 (1.17)	3.16* (1.40)	3.24* (1.52)

(continued)

Appendix Continued.

	(1) Trips	(2) Countries	(3) Days
Divided X Polarization	−1.30 (1.03)	−1.39 (1.23)	−1.64 (1.33)
Election Year (t)	−0.37* (0.18)	−0.43 (0.22)	−0.35 (0.23)
Lame Duck (t, Categorical, Final 2 years)	0.38** (0.13)	0.42** (0.15)	0.40* (0.16)
Constant	0.08 (0.92)	1.01 (1.09)	2.05 (1.17)
<i>N</i>	117	117	117

Poisson Count models with serial autocorrelation (1 lag) of the dependent variable. Using arpois package in Stata. Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.